containing the commissariat stores, on which the very existence of the force depended.'[48]

On 4 November, Hugh Johnson, the paymaster of Shah Shuja's force, went to Elphinstone and explained the situation with stark clarity. He told the General that 'there were but two days' provisions left in cantonments . . . that we could not procure supplies from the surrounding country with the enemy out in force in the neighbouring forts, and [that] the consequent destruction of our force [was inevitable] from famine, unless the Commissariat Fort were taken possession of at all hazards'. Elphinstone reluctantly agreed with Johnson's analysis, and sent a message to the defender of the fort, Ensign Warren of the 5th Native Infantry, 'a man of cool determined courage, who said little and always went about with a couple of bulldogs at his heels', telling him that a relief force would be sent to him at two in the morning. He then did nothing to bring the promise to fulfilment. Warren replied with a stream of messages begging for immediate assistance and explaining that unless he were relieved without delay he would have to abandon his position as much of his guard, which initially had been only seventy men strong, had now run away. The following morning at five o'clock, the commissariat fort was finally abandoned, Warren and his handful of men having bravely waited a full three hours beyond the time by which Elphinstone had promised to relieve them. 'The enemy then took immediate possession,' wrote Lady Sale, 'depriving us of [almost] our only means of subsistence.'

This left just one centre of British supplies intact, the Qal'a Nishan Khan, commanded by Colin Mackenzie, which still contained the ample supplies collected for Shah Shuja's force. From their parapets, the defenders watched glumly 'the scene of plunder going on in Trevor's house,' wrote Mackenzie; 'and the enemy, taking possession of the top, which overlooked my defences, pitched their balls from their large jezails with such accuracy as to clear my western face of defenders.' His account continued:

> It was only by crawling on my hands and knees up a small flight of steps and whisking suddenly through the door that I could even visit the tower that was being undermined. On one of these visits the sentry told me that there was an Afghan taking aim from an opposite loophole, but I could not see him. As I moved my head, the sentry clapped his eye to the slit, and fell dead at my feet with a ball through his forehead . . . In the afternoon the enemy brought down a large wall piece against us, the balls from which shook the upper part of one of our towers. The disposition to despair was increased by the utter failure of our last ammunition . . .